Chapter Seventy-Three

The Will to War

Between 1349 and 1369,
Charles of Navarre tries to seize the throne of France,
the king of Castile makes himself unpopular,
the peasants of France revolt,
and France and England find new excuses to fight

Between October 1349 and August 1350, three monarchs died of plague.

The first royal victim was Joan, queen of Navarre. Thirty-two years before, she had been denied the French throne by her uncle's invocation of the Salic Law. That same law had led to the ending of the Capetian dynasty and to the installation of her distant relative, Philip VI of Valois, on the French throne.

Ten months after Joan's death, on August 22, 1350, Philip VI of France—fifty-two years old, newly married to Joan's nineteen-year-old daughter—also died of plague.*

The plague had already killed King Alfonso XI of León-Castile; he had